it went about the job it had been trained for, first with the African witch doctor and then with Dr.Somu. Dr.Krishnan's clinic, usually a noisy sea of tears and **tantrums**, was transformed into a calm, orderly place as Zigzag efficiently soothed the frightened patients, scolded the naughty ones and made the crying ones smile. And if his yam-digging song and recitation of French poetry reduced the children to helpless laughter instead of tears, he didn't look as though he minded. And best of all, Zigzag never slept. Or snored. Even for a second!

Never had a morning passed so quietly and peacefully for Dr.Krishnan. When the last patient had left, he called Zigzag to his room. Zigzag flew in and sat on the table. Scratching the bird under its beak, Dr.Krishnan sighed and said, 'Somu was right, after all. You are an absolute treasure. I never realized what he meant when he called you *a great help*. Why didn't you tell me you'd prefer to be at my clinic instead of snoring like that to show you were bored? What do we do now? No one wants you back at home now; they want me to leave you with Visu.'

Just then the telephone rang. It was Mrs.Krishnan, sounding very pleased with herself. 'You know Mrs.Jhunjhunwula, the art critic?' she chuckled. 'She doesn't want me to exhibit sunset at marina. She's bought it for herself, for ₹ 5,000!'

Isn't that the painting the papaya fell on …..?

'Yes.' Mrs.Krishnan was laughing heartily now. I had left it in one corner and she chose to buy it, saying she loved my new technique of painting! She simply adored those streaky orangey bits! She launched into fresh gales of laughter. 'By the way,' she said when she sobered down, 'I don't think we were fair to Zigzag. Shall we keep him with us at home, just on trial for another week?'

'Sure!', agreed a delighted Dr.Krishnan before he cleverly added. 'And I could always take him to the clinic every morning so that you can paint in peace at home.'

'My boy!' he confided to Zigzag after matters were satisfactorily settled, giving the bird a toffee from his desk. 'You have your own strange way of showing your genius. A Zigzag way, I'd call it, wouldn't you?'

But Ziggy - Zagga - King - of - the -Tonga, brought up on compliments as he was, didn't bother to reply. He just ate the toffee, paper wrapper and all, and then lowered one crinkly eyelid in a knowing wink.

About the author



Asha Nehemiah born in 1958 at Chennai has lived, studied and worked in 8 different cities and small towns and is now a resident of Bangalore. She has always been interested in writing .Her love for reading , led her to study Literature in college. If she had not been a writer, she would have been a teacher . Humour, fantasy mystery and adventure are the strong elements in her work. She loves baking, walking, reading and travelling.

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